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Reportedly, Facebook is working on a similar feature like of snapchat, disappearing/self destructing messages!
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Different approaches to learning

1. Self-study/On-the-job training

There are a couple of ways by which you can get your foot in the door. One is by self-study and practice. There are students who've gained employment based solely on talent, enthusiasm and knowledge gained by themselves. As long as you have a good grasp on overall design, you'll be welcome anywhere. You can hone this craft from within your home (by say, watching tutorials on YouTube) and



India-based Anibrain worked on Guardians of the Galaxy

outshine others who've spent a fortune on university degrees and courses. "The most expensive school might not be the best school if it's not the right school for that particular artist," reiterates Danny of Lighthouse Animation Studios.

He further emphasizes, "It's one thing to know how to use a program, whatever program that may be. Anybody can learn how to use a program – what happens when you click here, what happens when you drag here, when you do this or that. It's another thing to implement your talent through that program." Most often it's only a matter of building on the areas in which you're strong and incorporating the skills in areas in which you're less so. Then, once hired – either in a paid position or as an intern initially – you can pick up additional skills on the job to add to your resume.

"If you're a fresher and you get in with a decent VFX company, then this is the best school. Now you go to these VFX schools which are good because they teach you the basics, but once you know the basics, the best thing to do is get out there and know the industry because you can't learn the industry in the classroom. You'll understand how it works by experiencing it yourself. So the best thing to do is work

with a VFX company under the guidance of a VFX supervisor, producer and often a digital effects supervisor."

2. Training schools and related institutes

Another way to learn the ropes is by joining VFX training schools and related institutes, either part-time or full-time, in person or online. These will take you six months to two years to complete based on the kind of course you choose and set you back by more than a lakh. Further, you must meet minimum educational require-



Nuke, a software tool you'll soon be working on like a pro

ments to get into a good training school, however this varies from institute to institute. "While some training institutes like FX School and NID take in candidates who've passed out of Class 10 and Class 12, respectively (from a recognised board, of course), others like Arena Multimedia accept students from all kinds of backgrounds," says Sekhar Mukherji, Head of Animation, National Institute of Design.

There are barely any specialised courses in India, so it's no surprise that

many VFX artists begin their careers with courses in fields other than VFX. For instance, they'll study Animation Film Design at NID, Visual Communication at Industrial Design Centre (IDC) or film making (sound, direction, editing, etc) at Film and Television Institute of India, where they achieve a wholesome experience by learning the way the industry is structured, pick up things relevant to their interests and then work in an industry of their own choice. "If the student is intelligent enough they pick up quickly," says Sekhar. He continues, "Three animation graduates from NID are today part of Firefly Creative Studio, one of the VFX studios that worked on Baahubali". Companies are more interested in whether you can help run their business, rather than where you've studied.

Further, while training focus at institutes like Maya Academy of Advanced Cinematics (MAAC), Whistling Woods Studio, Xplora Design Skool (XDS) and Frameboxx is on visual FX, they only teach you the software and its applications. Hence, most VFX artists that we have today are those who have learnt on their jobs.

IS IT WORTH STUDYING VFX ABROAD?

The allure of studying abroad can be intoxicating, so it's best to weigh the pros and cons before making the move. One thing is for sure: It will improve your marketability and provide you with better exposure on a global scale. Also, industry experts advise that if you want to work abroad then studying abroad is recommended. However, that doesn't mean that if you study in India, you won't be able to work outside the country.

A DAY IN THE LIFE OF A TYPICAL VFX ARTIST

Despite it being a job with long hours, "it's a fun environment to work in considering there's a constant influx of ideas and inspiration to gather. Your co-workers are your family because you're sitting there next to each other. Each department has to work together," says Suresh. Also, no two days are the same, which means you won't be working the

RECOMMENDED INSTITUTES

- Anibrain XDI, Pune
- DSK SupInfocom, Pune
- National Institute of Design (NID), Ahmedabad
- Whistling Woods International Institute, Mumbai
- Maya Academy of Advanced Cinematics (MAAC)
- Frameboxx Animation & Visual Effects
- Xplora Design Skool (XDS)
- Raffles Millennium International, Bengaluru
- Industrial Design Centre (IDC), Mumbai